

erage bank client moves less often than the average bank has been restructured. Instead of getting some benefit from their loyalty, longtime customers are forced to reintroduce themselves to a succession of new presidents, officers, or tellers and must show their driver's licenses again and again for identification, as if they—and not the institution—had just arrived in town.

Inside the doors of banks and S&Ls I found rate charts that explain all the options. These charts have gotten progressively more complicated as more features are added. At Chase Federal they offered the one-year CD, the two-year CD, the three-year CD, the four-year CD, and the five-year CD, plus the “tiered rate passbook” and a “tiered rate money market” to go along with “tiered rate checking” and the silver VISA card.

I informed Linden Barrett, a friendly young teller at Chase, that I had a large amount of money to put on deposit—enough to deserve at least one toaster. Mr. Barrett said his institution no longer gave away toasters. Keeping to its own core business, Chase Federal was giving away money. Mr. Barrett offered a \$20 cash bonus for every \$10,000 I'd invest in the one-year CD, \$40 for every \$10,000 in the two-year CD. Curiously, there was no bonus for the five-year CD.

At competing institutions, I found savings with checking, checking with savings, floating rate and capped, minimum balance and no minimum balance, service charge and no service charge, automatic transfer, among other options. There were variable-rate CDs and fixed-rate CDs with different maturity dates. I confided to an officer of one bank that I was interested in the stock market. He said the bank would be delighted to serve as my broker. “We can save you money on commissions,” he insisted. “We're much lower than Merrill Lynch.” Merrill Lynch, I later discovered, was not standing still for this. They'd be delighted to serve as my banker.

At Sun Bank, née Flagship, née United National, a large neon sign flashed a message to all holders of the 24-hour money card: PICK UP YOUR FREE GIFT. Beyond the lobby was a median strip of flowers, and beyond the median strip the grazing area for bank officers. Amid ten or twelve desks and a huge expanse of carpet, I saw only three people at work. As I waited in the reception area,